

Baltimore Orioles — Extension Decision Memo

Player: Adley Rutschman (C)

Executive Summary

Recommendation: Extend only under team-friendly, variance-sharing terms; otherwise defer a long-term guarantee and revisit after 2026.

Max offer (recommended): 7 years / \$135M guaranteed (2026–2032) + 1-year club option (2033) at \$20M with \$5M buyout.

Structure: front-loaded signing bonus + moderate salaries, incentives for catcher workload and awards, and annual games-caught/PA triggers that can convert the option to a vesting year in upside outcomes.

Why: Rutschman remains a top-tier two-way catcher, but our internal regression check of 2022–2025 indicators shows a clear step down in offensive production and (smaller) declines in catcher defensive runs. With multiple other 3–6 WAR position players projected for 2026 and significant guaranteed money already allocated (notably the new Pete Alonso commitment), we should avoid concentrating too large a share of payroll into a single catcher aging curve.

Item	Value
2026 projected WAR (FG Depth Charts)	3.7
2026–2032 WAR (median; range)	16.1
Implied value @ \$8.5M/WAR	136.85
Recommended guarantee	\$135M + 2033 club option

1) Career-to-date + regression signals (2022–2025)

I have provided the following visual aids to show Adley's year over year production.

- Offensive production has stepped down: wOBA fell from 0.354–0.352 to 0.309 and 0.298; xwOBA is flatter but also lower in 2024–2025.
- wOBA much higher vs LHP than RHP: could plateau with Basallo
- Counting stats showing regression, but coming off his best seasons for plate discipline and contact quality.
- Workload remains substantial (catching innings are stable/high outside of last year), which increases long-horizon durability risk for a multi-year guarantee.

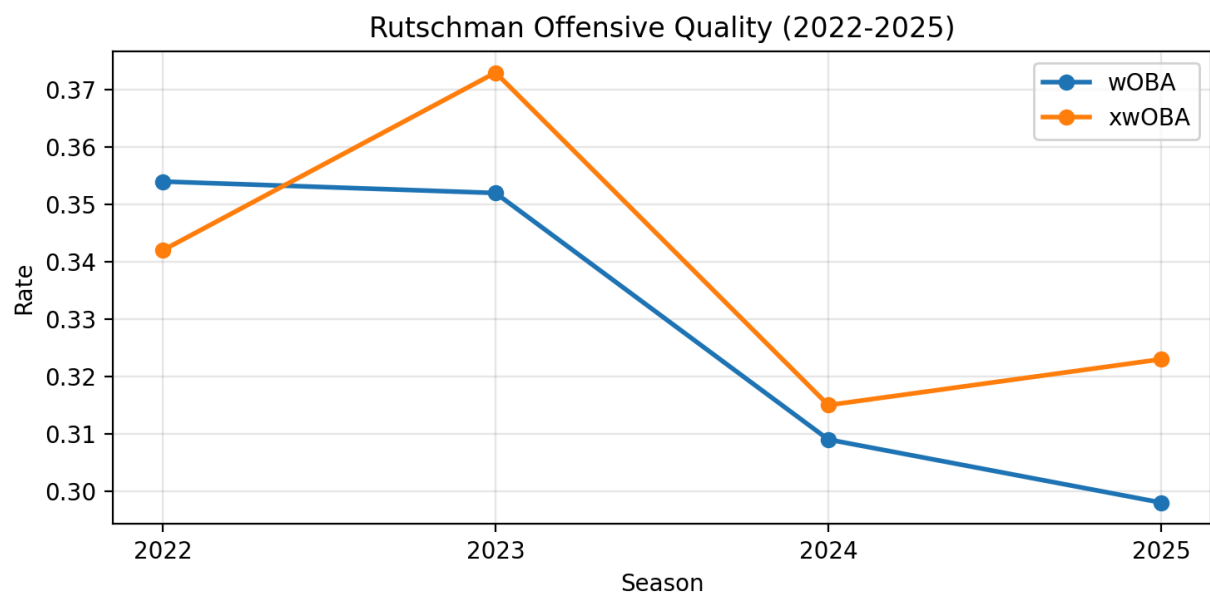


Figure 1. wOBA and xwOBBA trend

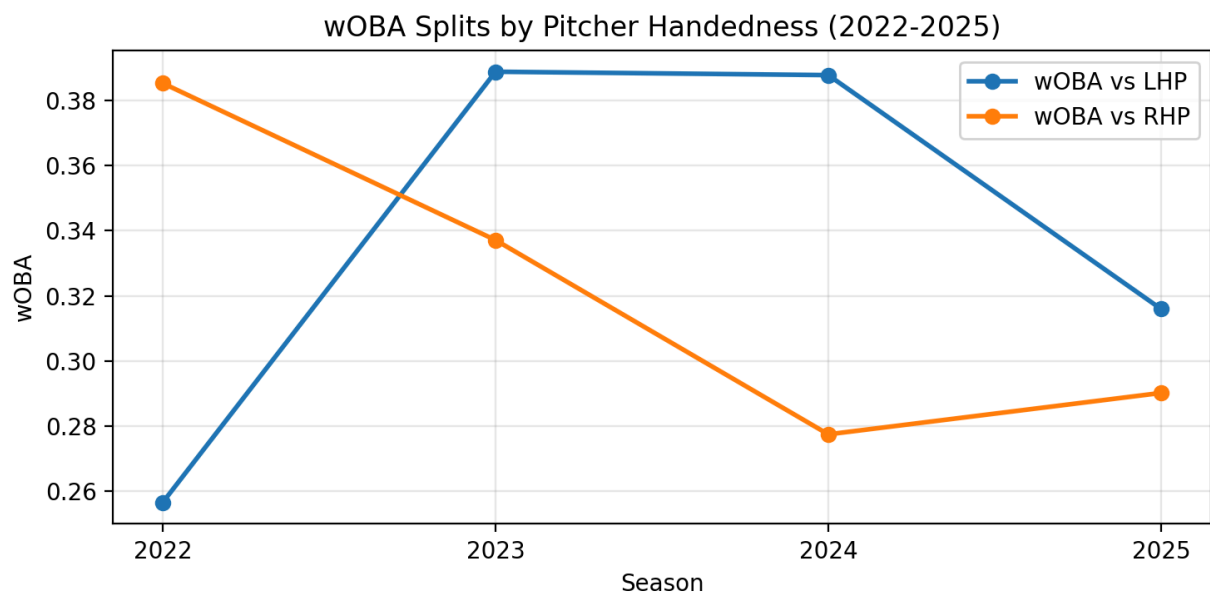


Figure 2. wOBA splits by pitcher handedness

Metric	2022	2023	2024	2025
BA	0.254	0.277	0.25	0.22
SLG	0.445	0.435	0.391	0.366
wOBA	0.354	0.352	0.309	0.298
xwOBA	0.342	0.373	0.315	0.323
Hard Hit %	36.8%	38.6%	36.6%	38.6%
Barrel %	7.9%	7.5%	6.1%	7.5%
Out of Zone Swing %	23.1%	23.4%	28.9%	21.7%
Whiff %	17.9%	15.6%	17.1%	14.5%
Catching Runs	15	6	4	2
BlocksAboveAvg	18	9	10	2
CSAboveAvg	3	0	1	-1
Innings as Catcher	762	935	882	573

Table 1. Stats by year

2) Roster value + payroll context (FanGraphs RosterResource)

We anchored roster context to FanGraphs RosterResource payroll and the Orioles' 2026 Depth Charts (playing-time based). The 2026 projection has multiple cornerstone bats beyond Rutschman, including Gunnar Henderson (6.0 WAR), Jordan Westburg (3.6), Jackson Holliday (2.7), and the newly-signed Pete Alonso (3.0). This matters because the marginal value of locking up one more win from the catcher position is constrained by (a) overall payroll capacity and (b) competing extension/arbitration priorities at premium positions.

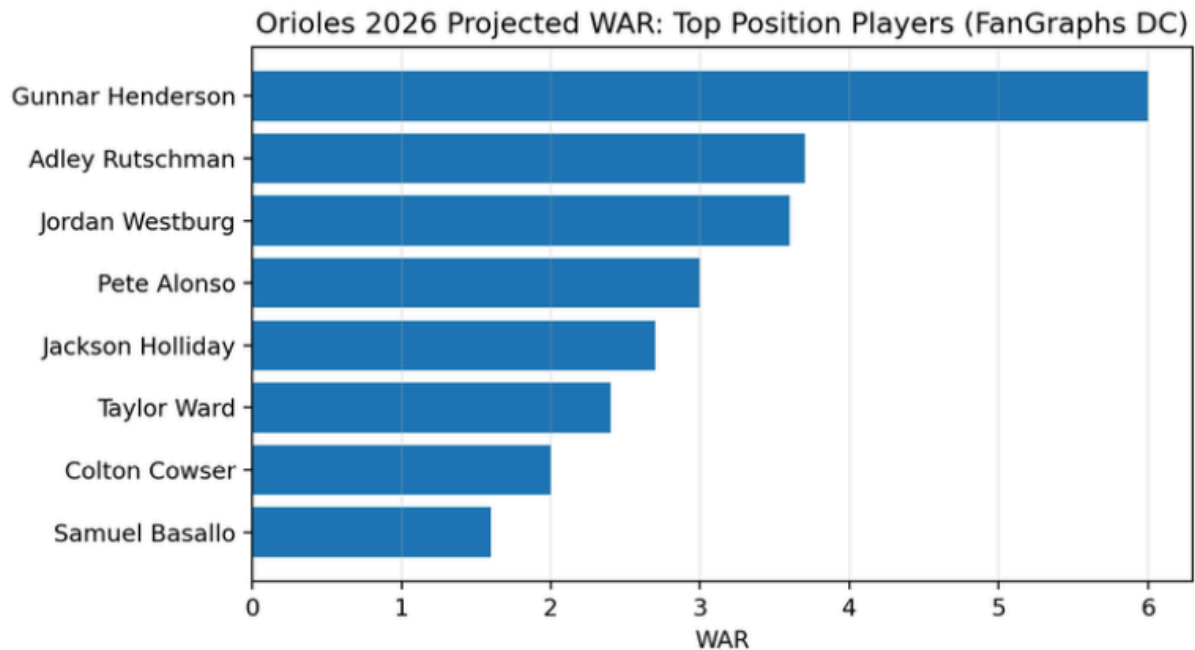
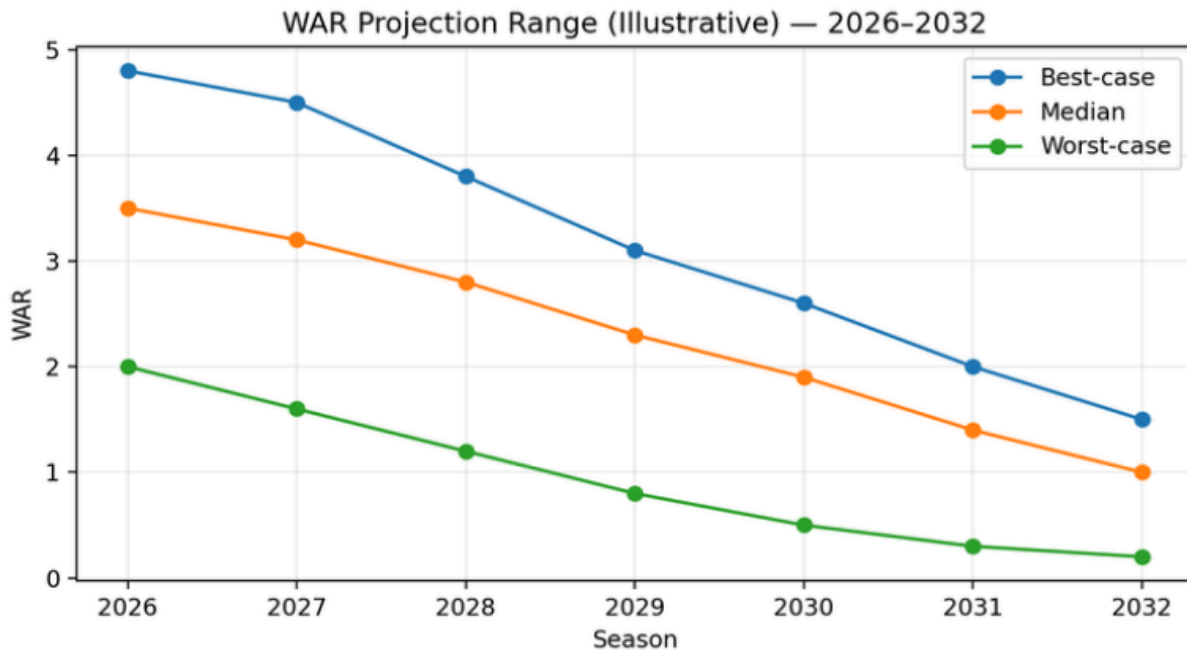


Figure 3. Projected 2026 WAR by position players, Orioles

Notable guaranteed commitments on the 2026 payroll page include: Pete Alonso (5 years / \$155M, 2026–2030), Tyler O’Neill (3 years / \$49.5M, 2025–2027), Samuel Basallo (8 years / \$67M, 2026–2033 with 2034 club option), plus several shorter-term pitching commitments/options. These existing deals reduce tolerance for a catcher extension that “prices in” an optimistic rebound.

2) Projections



Baseline: Start from 2026 FanGraphs Depth Charts playing-time projection (3.7 WAR) and adjust conservatively based on 2024–2025 indicator slippage (wOBA/xwOBA, contact quality) and catcher defense trend.

Aging: Apply catcher-specific aging where offensive value and defensive components drift downward into the early 30s, with additional downside if workload forces more 1B/DH time (reducing positional value) or if receiving/throwing decline.

Output: Use ranges (best/median/worst) rather than a point estimate. For valuation, translate WAR to dollars using a \$/WAR baseline that reflects a 2026 free-agent market and ongoing inflation in contracts.

Scenarios:

<u>Scenario</u>	<u>Probability</u>	<u>2026-2032 WAR</u>
Best Case	25%	25.0
Median	50%	16.1
Worst-case	25%	8.8

- Best-Case - offense returns to near 2022-2023 progression levels
- Median: Solid regular positional player with gradual decline; consider shift to 1B after Alonso's deal is up
- Worst-Case: Offensive regression and reduced innings catching continue

Market comparables (catcher deals)

- Will Smith: 10 years / \$140M extension (Dodgers, March 2024; includes signing bonus and deferrals).
- Sean Murphy: 6 years / \$73M extension (Braves, December 2022; includes a 2029 club option).

These deals suggest that long guarantees for catchers are achievable, but they also show how teams manage risk via options/deferrals/structure.

Proposed offer (immediate, pre-arb buyout)

Guaranteed: 7 years / \$135M (2026–2032)

Option: 2033 club option \$25M (vesting to player option if 2029–2032 workload triggers are met) with \$5M buyout.

- Incentives (annual): \$1M each for 110+ games caught, 500+ PA, Gold Glove / Silver Slugger, and top-10 MVP finish (capped).
- Role protection: if shifted to 1B/DH for non-injury reasons, incentive eligibility remains; if shift is injury-driven, incentives scale with PA.

Overpay safeguard: Do not exceed 8 years / \$210M guaranteed without a clear 2026 rebound in offense AND stable catcher defensive value. Above this level, expected surplus becomes negative in a non-trivial portion of outcomes.

Acceptance likelihood: ~45–55%.

Reasoning: the guarantee is large for a pre-arb catcher and offers immediate security, but it does not pay for the absolute upside and includes option/vesting mechanics that strongly protect the club.

5) Sensitivity analysis (what changes the decision)

Key sensitivities:

1. Offense trajectory: if 2026 wOBA/xwOBA and contact-quality indicators rebound toward 2022–2023, our median WAR path increases materially and an 8-year structure becomes more defensible.
2. Defensive persistence: if receiving/framing signals stabilize (or if the new receiving environment makes elite catching more valuable), downside probability shrinks.
3. Payroll opportunity cost: new commitments (e.g., large AAV additions) reduce the amount of surplus we should allocate to one player. Conversely, if the club has additional payroll growth capacity, risk tolerance increases.